formed and, according to Eric S. Margolis, ‘Accurate surveys were begun of the hitherto unchartered Himalayan and Ladakh border regions. Disputed Kashmir suddenly assumed heightened strategic importance as Delhi worried that China had designs on the mountain state, or that it might join Pakistan in a coordinated assault on northern India.’[54]

The 1962 Sino-Indian War and the 1965 war with Pakistan, prompted India to improve its intelligence-gathering capabilities. The solution came in September 1968, when Indira Gandhi’s government set up a new external spy agency, the Research and Analysis Wing, R&AW, better known to its operatives as simply ‘RAW’. Its first head was Rameshwar Nath Kao, who had served under Bhola Nath Mullik in the Intelligence Bureau. His official designation was Secretary (Research) in the prime minister’s cabinet secretariat, of which RAW was a ‘wing’. He became India’s first true spymaster and the organization he headed grew over the years to become one of the world’s largest and most active intelligence agencies.

India’s regular military forces were also strengthened. After the 1962 War, India ordered 400 T-54 medium tanks from the Soviet Union, which would be of no use in the mountains, but could be deployed against Pakistan. India’s request to buy F-104 interceptor aircraft from the USA fell through because Washington did not want to antagonize its ally, Pakistan. But a factory to produce the Soviet’s MiG-21 was already being planned. Now, in 1963, the first squadron of MiG-21Fs entered service in the Indian Air Force.[55] While Pakistan was still seen as the immediate threat, ‘India’s leaders were becoming convinced that China represented a long-term territorial rival. In 1963, India began secret development of a nuclear weapons program.’[56]

India’s own defence industries, which had been established at the initiative of Menon when he was India’s defence minister in the 1950s, were upgraded with the help of technical expertise mainly from the Soviet Union. The old garrison town of Bangalore, now Bengaluru, in the south, far away from India’s troubled borders, was chosen as the site for the development of an indigenous electronics industry in the 1950s. Large research laboratories such as the National Aeronautical Laboratory and the Electronic Research and Development Establishment were established in Bangalore. Bharat Electronics Limited was established in the city in 1954